



Origin and Background

The concept of theatrical status was pioneered by Keith Johnstone in his foundational 1979 book, *Impro: Improvisation and the Theatre*.

*Status is not an inherent trait, but a continuous series of **transactions**. Every interaction involves raising or lowering one's own status relative to another. In applied contexts, recognizing these micro-behaviors allows individuals to **consciously adjust power dynamics** rather than reacting on instinct.*

-Johnstone

Execution Guide

Materials Needed:

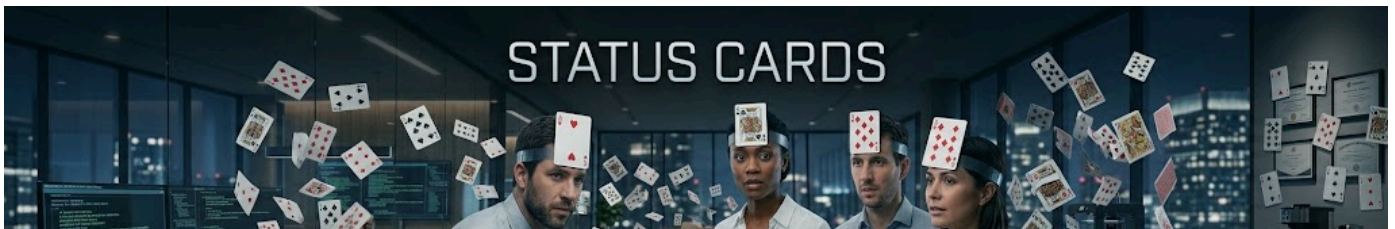
- A standard deck of playing cards:
 - *Simplest*: Only one of each rank
 - *Intermediate*: Multiples of some ranks
 - *Advanced*: Add in the Joker and Ace with no explanation of rank
- Elastic headbands or gluesticks might be helpful to keep the cards attached

Setup:

1. Each participant should come up with a secret character and objective.
2. Shuffle the deck and hand one card to each participant face down.
3. Instruct participants to hold/attach the card to their forehead facing outward.
4. Participants must ensure everyone else can see their card, but they must not see their own.
5. It is best to keep the cards visible during the scene.

Rank

King
Queen
Jack
10
9
8
7
6
5
4
3
2
Ace?
Joker?



The Rules of Engagement:

- **The Objective:** Participants must determine their own relative status based entirely on how others interact with them.
- **The Constraint:** Participants cannot explicitly state numbers or rank (e.g., "You are a lowly two"). Interactions must rely on tone, body language, space, and conversational control.
- **The Scenario:** Establish a neutral setting, such as a corporate networking event, a waiting room, or a company holiday party.
- **The Interaction:** Participants mingle and converse. They must treat others with the level of deference or dominance dictated by the number on the other person's forehead relative to what they believe their own status rank.

The Line-up:

1. Stop the exercise after 5 to 10 minutes or when it becomes clear that everyone has figured out their status.
2. Instruct participants to line up in a single file from what they believe is the lowest status to the highest status. They must do this without speaking.
3. Once settled, have everyone remove their cards and look at their actual rank.

Best Practices & Tips

- **Emphasize Physicality:** Encourage the use of space. High-status characters typically take up more room, maintain steady eye contact, and move smoothly. Low-status characters often touch their face, break eye contact, make jerky movements, and yield physical space.
- **Focus on Vocal Delivery:** High status is conveyed through steady volume, speaking in complete sentences, and comfort with silence. Low status is conveyed through hesitations ("um," "er"), speaking quickly, trailing off, or asking permission to speak.
- **Rotate the Extremes:** Ensure the extreme cards (2s and Kings) are given to different types of personalities if doing multiple rounds. Forcing a naturally dominant person to play a 2, or a quiet person to play a King, maximizes the learning outcome.

Debrief Questions

- What specific behaviors tipped you off to your status?
- How did your physical posture change once you assumed you were high or low status?
- For those holding mid-range cards (7s, 8s), how did you navigate interactions with both extremes?



- How can consciously adopting a high status be weaponized during a social engineering engagement?
- When could low status also be useful?
- When attempting to bypass a receptionist or a security guard, which status level is most likely to achieve compliance without raising suspicion?

Canonical Sources and Further Reading

- **The AMA Journal of Ethics Article:** [How to Use Improv to Help Interprofessional Students Respond to Status and Hierarchy in Clinical Practice](#).
 - **Summary:** This article details how applied improv—specifically the Status Cards exercise—is used to train medical students. It highlights how recognizing fluid power dynamics helps subordinate staff navigate rigid clinical hierarchies, speak up to authority figures, and ultimately improve teamwork and patient safety. The methodology directly parallels the requirement to read and manipulate corporate hierarchies during security engagements.
- **Keith Johnstone's *Impro*:** The definitive text on status work. The chapter simply titled "Status" breaks down the exact physical and verbal cues humans use to establish dominance and submission. [Improv: Improvisation and the Theatre \(Routledge Edition\)](#).
- **Applied Improvisation Network:** A global professional network dedicated to using improv techniques in non-theatrical, corporate, and educational settings. Their resources often detail variations of status games. [Applied Improvisation Network \(AIN\)](#).